2022 showed that Covid patients—four and a half months after testing positive—had lost 0.2-2 per cent more grey matter than those who had not been infected. This was the first large study that had pre-Covid data to rely on and was able to prove what others had been merely hypothesising about since the pandemic began—the virus indeed causes brain damage and worsens pre-existing neurological problems.

In those who have had moderate to severe Covid, the brain can get impaired in a way equivalent to ageing 20 years, concludes an April 2022 study by NIHR Cambridge Biomedical Research Centre published in *eClinicalMedicine*. Looking at around 66,000 patients, the study shows the magnitude of cognitive loss is similar to losing 10 IQ points. Moreover, an April 2021 study published in *JAMA* finds that those who had Covid run double the risk of suffering strokes compared to others of the same age, sex and ethnicity. "Internal inflammation caused by Covid can cause blood clots that are as harmful for the brain as for any other organ," says Dr Srivastava. "Even a minor heart palpitation should not be ignored. The heart and the brain are closely linked and signs of trouble in one could indicate trouble in the other."

Dr Srivastava says a rush to "return to normality" and lack of awareness and preventive check-ups during recovery can worsen brain health. "There is no guarantee about what could go wrong. One should monitor health and follow medical advice," she adds. Most doctors agree that the possibility of brain problems does not mean something will go wrong. "Panic doesn't solve anything. The added stress can actually worsen your condition," says Dr P.N. Renjen, a senior neurologist at Apollo Hospitals, Delhi. "Understanding the risks and mitigating them safeguards and improves brain health." Unlike two years ago, there are fairly substantive insights now into how Covid affects the brain. That's the first step towards prevention.

TIPS FOR POST-COVID BRAIN HEALTH

What you can do to counter the long-term effects of the coronavirus on your brain

DIAGNOSIS: The root cause of your symptoms should be ascertained. Blood tests–CRP, IL-6, CBC and D-dimer–are a first step towards finding out if there is a need for brain imaging or a cerebrospinal fluid test

REST: Research shows 8-10 hours of sleep in the night is crucial for the brain to heal. Doctors recommend a wind-down routine–eating 3 hours before bed, turning off screens an hour before sleep and meditation or writing down worries

DIET: Nutrition helps the brain recuperate–foods rich in vitamin B12, vitamin E and antioxidants are recommended. Nuts, dairy, fish and seeds are rich in serotonin that can help improve mood and reduce stress

GRADED EXERCISE: Slowly return to heavy physical exercise–with no more than five minutes of cardio per day in the first two or three weeks, depending on how severe your illness was. Movement is important for healing but it should be eased into

SOCIALISING: Talking to friends and family is important not just to reduce emotional stress but also to gain perspective on the next steps to take. Often, people don't realise they are experiencing brain fog until someone informs them



"Understanding the risks and taking steps to mitigate them can help safeguard and improve brain health"

Dr P.N. Renjen, *Senior Neurologist, Apollo Hospitals, Delhi*

DOES COVID INFECT THE BRAIN?

If there is still some scepticism around whether Covid-induced brain fog is real or just an internet label, it is partly due to doubts about the first study that established the term 'long Covid'—a May 2020 online survey by queer femi-